

Link to story: <https://www.campfirewriting.com/explore/what-the-water-remembers>

Instruction: Click on the link then go to the Home Page button to read the story and the character bio

Rationale:

“What the Water Remembers” is an unofficial transmedia extension of Avatar: The Last Airbender (ATLA, Nickelodeon, 2005), presented as a handwritten journal discovered in the Northern Water Tribe archive. It was written from the perspective of Sena, an original healer living before the hundred-year war. The journal reveals forbidden knowledge about waterbending’s spiritual origins and an ancient sealed spirit. This text does not retell existing events. It illustrated what Jenkins (2006, cited in Webster, Leaver & Sandry 2022) defines the quality of transmedia storytelling: a technique of telling stories across multiple platforms and formats, with each element making distinctive contributions to a fan’s understanding of the story world.

The journal operates as a “what if” extension in Mittell’s (2015) framework, exploring hypothetical possibilities within the Avatar storyworld rather than strict canonical certainties. The unnamed sealed spirit, Sen’s unmeasurable soul energy and the suggestion that water bending originates from divine spiritual memory are possibilities the series never confirmed, inviting audiences to imagine deeper mythology beneath what the show revealed. This framing activates what Mittell (2015) terms drillabilitythe reward for deep fan egagement. A casual reader will encounter Sena’s story as atmosphere dark fantasy. However, an ATLA fan recognising Princess Yue - a girl who gave her life to become the Moon Spirit or understanding the significance of Wan Shi Tong’s Library being sealed from humans will experience these as layered revelations, feeling the full weight of what Sena uncovers in ways a newcomer cannot.

The transmedia text was developed using Campfire Writing ([campfirewriting.com](https://www.campfirewriting.com)), a world-building platform designed specifically for novelists and worldbuilders. Campfire’s character, location, and lore modules allowed the construction of a coherent story bible for Sena’s world, including detailed character profiles, pre-war Northern Water Tribe geography, and the spiritual system underlying the sealed realm - ensuring the extension remains internally consistent with ATLA’s established universe. This process directly reflects Gomez’s (2007) third and fifth characteristics of successful transmedia: content distributed across platforms grounded in a single, coherent vision of the storyworld. By building the world systematically before writing, the journal avoids the fractures and inconsistencies Gomez (2007) identifies as key reasons transmedia projects fail.

Klastrup and Tosca (2014) argue that successful transmedial worlds must authentically extend three dimensions: mythos, topos, and ethos. The mythos is expanded through new Spirit World lore - the sealed realm, the unmeasurable soul, spirits that cannot locate Sena. The topos is grounded in “the archive beneath the elder hall” of the Northern Water Tribe. The ethos is extended through the closing lines - “Never technique. Never rank. Never gender” - honouring ATLA’s moral framework while pushing its gender politics further than series did.

As Jenkins (quoted in Green 2026) argues, storytelling has become the art of world building, creating environments that cannot be fully explored within a single medium. The journal's entry point reading something never meant to be found, through a margin note reading "Do not open the third scroll. Not yet" immediately followed by " I opened it last night" creates intimacy animation cannot replicate. As Webster et al (2022) note, the meta-narrative experience must be greater than the sum of its parts. Read alongside ATLA, Sena's journal reframes what waterbending has always meant and asks the questions the show never did: what does the water remember?



Reference List

Gomez, J 2007, *8 defining characteristics of transmedia production*, Starlight Runner Entertainment.

Green, B 2026, 'Week 2: Transmedia culture', PowerPoint slides, COMM2631, RMIT University, Melbourne.

Klastrup, L & Tosca, S 2014, 'Game of Thrones: transmedial worlds, fandom, and social gaming', in ML Ryan & JN Thon (eds), *Storyworlds across media: toward a media-conscious narratology*, University of Nebraska Press, Lincoln, pp. 295-314.

Mittell, J 2015, *Complex TV: the poetics of contemporary television storytelling*, New York University Press, New York.

Webster, L, Leaver, T & Sandry, E 2022, 'Transmedia storytelling during the COVID-19 pandemic: Marvel's WandaVision and Zack Snyder's Justice League', *First Monday*, vol. 27, no. 7.